

Modern society and prospects of low vitamin B12 intake.

BACKGROUND: Vitamin B(12) deficiency can occur in individuals with dietary patterns that exclude animal foods and patients who are unable to absorb vitamin B(12) in food. MATERIAL AND METHOD: Our clinic serves a high-income population living in Southern Israel. We hypothesize that a tendency to decrease of level of vitamin B(12) in our population is caused by a premeditated decrease in consumption of animal products. We analyzed 512 medical histories of patients undergoing blood tests for vitamin B(12) level for various reasons. RESULT: The level of vitamin B(12) in 192 patients (37.5%) was less than 250 pg/ml. CONCLUSION: As a result of media information disseminating the relationship between meat, cholesterol and cardiovascular diseases, consumption of meat, particularly beef, has decreased. Changes in life style among segments of the population with high socioeconomic level, on one hand, and the existence of poverty, on the other, are two main factors in the decreasing consumption of animal products. This causes a decrease in the level of vitamin B(12) in the general population, and as a consequence, this will increase pathology due to vitamin B(12) deficiency. In lieu of these possible developments and in order to prevent serious health problems, vitamin B(12) fortification should be seriously considered and discussed. (c) 2007 S. Karger AG, Basel.